

Internet Connectivity Solutions

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Internet connectivity is among the basic necessities today. You will scarcely find a business in globalised India that does not depend on an internet connection in some way or the other. In fact, for most businesses, email, VoIP, and other web services are a lifeline. Ever since India became an off-shoring hub, many companies service clients abroad. Irrespective of usage, choosing the right internet connection is important – both from the functionality as well as cost saving viewpoint. Let's look at some of the factors involved while zeroing in on a suitable connection.

The options available

In the earlier days, life was restricted to painfully slow dial-up connections. For corporates that could afford it, there was ISDN which was a bit faster and was considered state-of-the art for quite some time. However, today the internet is more accessible.

DSL / ADSL works through existing two-wire copper telephone lines and is an always-on connection. MTNL's broadband service, based on ADSL 2+ technology, is known as Tri-Band. Tri-band offers speeds of up to 2 Mbps with an assured minimum speed of 256 kbps to individual telephone subscribers.

A leased line is another option. Such a leased line connects two locations for a private voice and data telecommunication service. Rather than a dedicated cable, a leased line is a reserved open circuit between two points, used to connect to the internet. When you go in for a leased line, there are no data limits.

Unlike normal dial-up connections, a leased line is always active, always on. The connection fee is a fixed monthly rate. The primary factors affecting the monthly fee are distance between end points and the speed of the circuit.

Wired cable connections are common in semi-urban office setups. Typically, local cable operators purchase bandwidth in bulk from large ISPs and channel them to individual subscribers. They have their own brand names for their service. There are also players like You Telecom that operates on last mile co-axial and fibre optic lines with cable modems. They have solutions for SMEs with unlimited plans such as the 'Business Platinum', 1 Mbps line for Rs. 9,500 per month.

Several players such as Airtel and Reliance Communications provide WiMax solutions for enterprises. WiMax stands for Worldwide Interoperability for Microwave Access, and is a standard wireless technology that allows broadband connections over long distances. However, the service is only available in certain major cities.

A typical Broadband Wireless Access (BWA) system is composed of two key elements – base station and subscriber equipment. The base station connects to the subscriber equipment using an outdoor antenna to send and receive high-speed data to the subscriber equipment; thereby, eliminating the need of wire line infrastructure and provides a flexible and cost-effective last-mile solution.

However, according to its web site, the bandwidth of the last mile wireless connectivity offered by Airtel is only up to 512 Kbps.

The choice now lies with what works best for you. The service provider plays a major role in this regard because inherently all transmission modes are almost equally susceptible to breakdowns. Your up-time will depend largely on the dedication of your ISP.

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